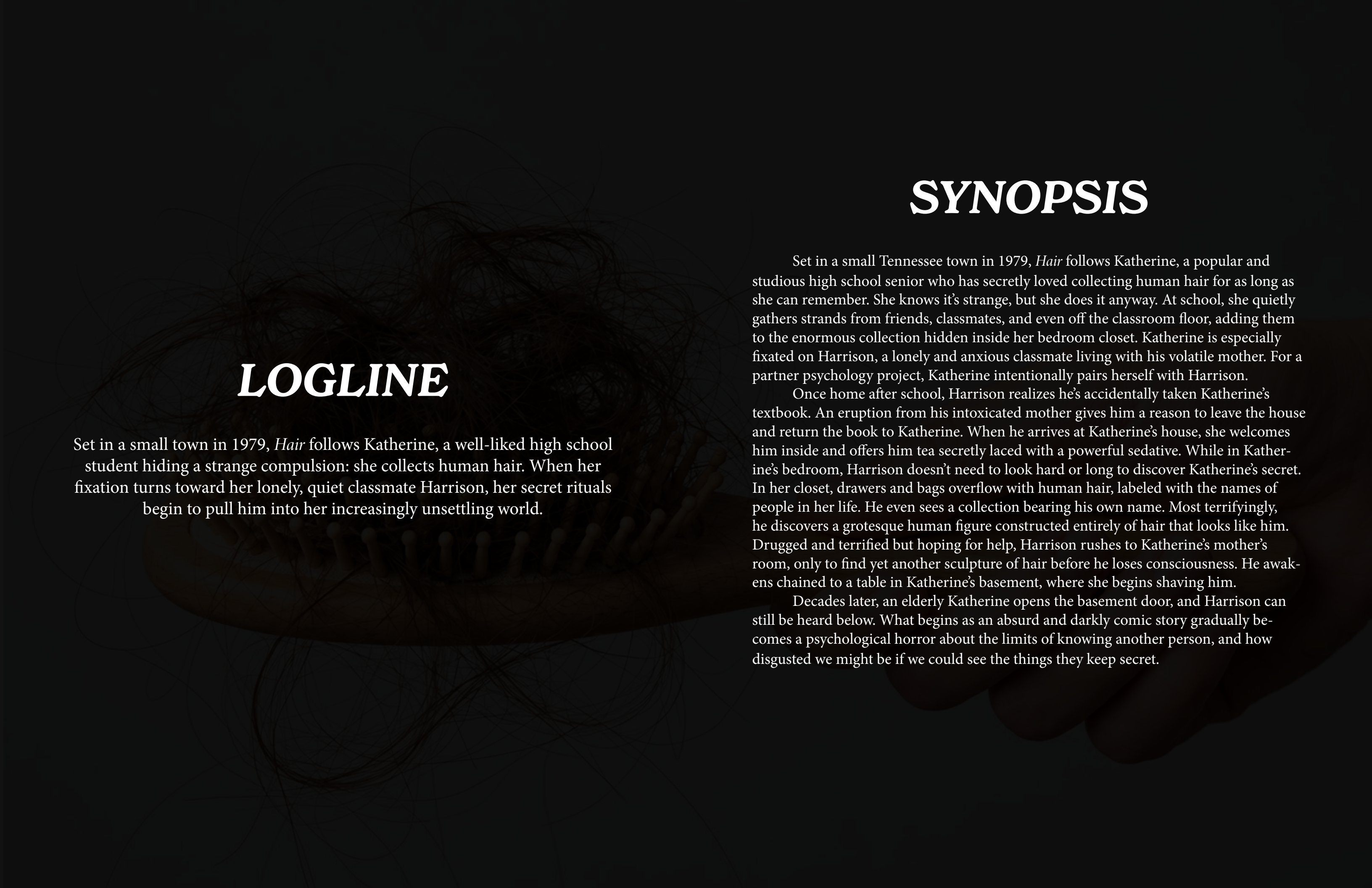




HAIR



LOGLINE

Set in a small town in 1979, *Hair* follows Katherine, a well-liked high school student hiding a strange compulsion: she collects human hair. When her fixation turns toward her lonely, quiet classmate Harrison, her secret rituals begin to pull him into her increasingly unsettling world.

SYNOPSIS

Set in a small Tennessee town in 1979, *Hair* follows Katherine, a popular and studious high school senior who has secretly loved collecting human hair for as long as she can remember. She knows it's strange, but she does it anyway. At school, she quietly gathers strands from friends, classmates, and even off the classroom floor, adding them to the enormous collection hidden inside her bedroom closet. Katherine is especially fixated on Harrison, a lonely and anxious classmate living with his volatile mother. For a partner psychology project, Katherine intentionally pairs herself with Harrison.

Once home after school, Harrison realizes he's accidentally taken Katherine's textbook. An eruption from his intoxicated mother gives him a reason to leave the house and return the book to Katherine. When he arrives at Katherine's house, she welcomes him inside and offers him tea secretly laced with a powerful sedative. While in Katherine's bedroom, Harrison doesn't need to look hard or long to discover Katherine's secret. In her closet, drawers and bags overflow with human hair, labeled with the names of people in her life. He even sees a collection bearing his own name. Most terrifyingly, he discovers a grotesque human figure constructed entirely of hair that looks like him. Drugged and terrified but hoping for help, Harrison rushes to Katherine's mother's room, only to find yet another sculpture of hair before he loses consciousness. He awakens chained to a table in Katherine's basement, where she begins shaving him.

Decades later, an elderly Katherine opens the basement door, and Harrison can still be heard below. What begins as an absurd and darkly comic story gradually becomes a psychological horror about the limits of knowing another person, and how disgusted we might be if we could see the things they keep secret.

DIRECTOR'S STATEMENT

The story behind *Hair* is, in some ways, as strange and coincidental as the film's plot. Before I explain the exact impetus for the project, I should begin with my longstanding love and respect for storytelling. As a middle-school student, I was not a particularly strong student or writer, but I deeply admired the craft of great writers, lyricists, poets, and painters. I remember my aunt sneaking me a Stephen King compilation— against my mother's wishes, I really wanted to read *The Langoliers*— and reading Stephen Crane's two-stanza poem "In the Desert" as the epigraph and feeling absolutely gutted. I remember a similar feeling the first time I viewed Dalí's *Dream Caused by the Flight of a Bee Around a Pomegranate a Second Before Awakening*. I loved that feeling of being confronted with my own humanity. Looking back, I think I've always wanted to create something that might make others feel what I felt then.

However, when I began dabbling in creative writing in 2008 as a middle-schooler, I did not have a clear goal beyond wanting to get better. I simply loved doing it. That has never really changed. Writing and storytelling have given me solace, purpose, and a way to work things out. Now, as a middle-school English teacher myself, I have the opportunity to share that same enthusiasm for stories and the humanities with my students. That persistence has recently begun to pay off; this year, one

of my flash-fiction stories placed first in its heat in the NYC Midnight international writing competition. *Hair* feels like a long-coming culmination of my love for story-telling.

I tried to write *Hair* as a short story because I'm most comfortable in that medium. But quickly, I realized this story was meant to be a screenplay. And I had never written a screenplay. That realization began years of teaching myself how to write a script and what it would take to make a movie. During those years, photography became another creative outlet and taught me to think about faces, light, color, composition, and how a single frame can imply a story, invoke emotion. Photography became the bridge between the writer I already was and the filmmaker I dreamed of being.

The premise of *Hair* almost feels wrong to take credit for. During a Sunday family lunch in 2022, one of my brothers shared a thought experiment with me. He was trying to create his own genre. While he later acknowledged he wasn't the first to arrive at something like it, he had independently come up with a set of parameters for what he was calling Realist Absurdist Horror: the story must be able to take place in the real world, but it must be so absurd that it almost certainly never would. His proposed genre emphasizes feelings of disgust, embarrassment, sadness, and dread.

Without missing a beat, I replied, "So, for example, like a girl who collects human hair and eventually abducts someone to harvest their hair?"

I am still not sure where that idea came from, but it fit my brother's description. As Stephen King wrote, "Your job isn't to find these ideas but to recognize them when they show up."

Admittedly, at first, I thought *Hair* was the perfect absurd idea to risk on my first attempt at filmmaking. But over the years, I have fallen deeply in love with the premise, the story, the characters, the symbolism and the contradictory nature of hair. I want to do this idea right.

After writing *Hair*, I began to understand why I loved the premise so much. I've always been drawn to the idea that you can never truly know someone. To me, the film became a metaphor for our private selves. We all have thoughts, impulses, fears, desires, and secrets that we would rarely or if ever willingly expose to another person. I became interested in a simple, uncomfortable question: How disgusted would we be if we could actually see the things other people keep private?

Hair was the perfect expression of that idea. On someone's head, hair can be beautiful. Detached from the body—in a drain, on the floor, or God forbid in your food— the exact same thing can become disgusting. Katherine's private collection makes this tangible for the audience. Her secret is absurd, but the

existence of a secret self is not.

Hair has become more personal than I ever expected it to be. The brother whose thought experiment inadvertently gave me the premise was a constant sounding board through the writing process and is now composing the film's score, while my other brothers have taken on roles throughout the production. My youngest brother serves in the U.S. Marine Corps in combat imagery, producing journalistic photo and video work, and I'm proud to have him as the cinematographer. What began as a strange conversation over a Sunday lunch has grown into something we're attempting to make together. For me, *Hair* feels like a culmination of who I have become as a writer, a learner, a photographer, a brother, and now, for the first time, a filmmaker.

VISUAL LANGUAGE

Drawing from my brother's journalistic background and my portrait sensibilities, *Hair* will treat its absurd subject matter with visual sincerity. The camera will not tell the audience that Katherine is strange before the story does. The world will initially feel real, ordinary, and mundane, with instances of nostalgia and even beauty as the rural Tennessee countryside is framed with restraint and naturalism. As Katherine's private world becomes visible to the audience, the filmmaking will not suddenly become conventionally horrific. The absurdity comes from treating the strange as ordinary.

Period detail will emerge naturally through wardrobe, vehicles, interiors, props rather than indulgently calling attention to itself. A very subtle diffusion filter will be used throughout the film, drawing from a staple of my portrait photography while gently softening skin and highlights. The effect will remain subdued, lending slightly less sharpness that evokes the period without overtly imitating vintage film.

My portrait background will be most apparent in the film's attention to faces and expression, allowing performance and interiority to carry frames. The camera will generally remain static, favoring careful compositions over movement. Most of *Hair* will engage with familiar cinematic conventions, with shots motivated by story, character, and performance rather than novelty. Because the film's baseline visual grammar remains grounded, occasional departures from that restraint can carry greater weight.



Zack's Work

Some of those departures include presenting Mr. Leverette only in fragments or reflections (to develop his characterization and a theme of superficiality), attaching the camera to a broom, using an in-camera filter effect as Harrison becomes drugged, and introducing chiaroscuro in the final basement scene. These moments should feel increasingly expressive without allowing the film itself to become self-aware.

Lighting will remain naturalistically motivated throughout most of the film, drawing from practicals, windows, and believable environmental sources. The basement scene will permit the strongest departure from that restraint.

Color will reinforce then subvert character without becoming too rigidly symbolic. *Hair* is concerned with the gap between appearance and interior life— people are often more than what they seem. Katherine's palette will lean toward blues associated with trust and stability, while Harrison's will draw more from warmer yellows associated with happiness and confidence. These colors will help establish the film's visual palette while remaining integrated into wardrobe, production design, and environment. However, the characters' backpacks will invert this relationship, each carrying the other's color as Harrison attempts to understand Katherine and Katherine increasingly attempts to possess Harrison. See the movie poster featuring Katherine's yellow backpack.

Isaiah's Work



WARDROBE NOTES

The following was given to our Wardrobe Lead, Isabel Heuer:

Hair is set in the late 1970s to early 1980s for narrative reasons, not necessarily nostalgia (though I do love this era). The period primarily removes modern technology and introduces a slower pace of life.

Wardrobe should feel ordinary. These are everyday people in a small Tennessee city. Avoid iconic or trend-driven period styling unless specifically motivated by characters, like Jessica and Amanda.

For the 15-25 extras at the school scenes, we could ask for extras to come in plain sneakers, jeans, or denim shorts, and then provide era-appropriate tops (I have several).

For leads, avoid: Bell bottoms. Bright polyester print. Platform shoes. Anything that feels like *Grease* or *Saturday Night Fever*.

Color language/psychology: I'd like to assign colors to the lead roles. The color psychology represents the opposite of who the characters truly are. So, Katherine is blue: calm and trust. Harrison is yellow: joy and hope. The audience should subconsciously trust Katherine and feel warmth from Harrison before the story gradually subverts those assumptions.

Katherine, age 18 (Lead Character):

It is important that she is seen as normal, even idealized- kind, well-liked, and studious. Her color is blue. Soft blues, white, silver, minimal patterns. She is the only character with more than one look. She's seen in her school outfit and later (in the story's climax) a bathrobe.



Jessica and Amanda, 18 (Supporting Characters):

With these characters, we could lean into the era a little bit more. They are there to establish Katherine's normality and popularity.

Harrison, 18 (Lead Character):

Quiet, lonely, and sincere. A Will Byers (*Stranger Things*) type. Harrison's color is yellow. Warm yellows, cream, tan, faded denim.



Mr. Leverette, 35 (Principal Supporting Character):

Tired, resigned, but a respected teacher. He has a quiet pride in his appearance and is always well dressed, professional but not flashy. Thematically he mirrors Katherine, so faded blues and grays could connect them.



CHARACTERS

The horror of *Hair* depends on its characters appearing ordinary before we understand what they keep private. Their visual identities will emerge from personality, period, and environment rather than conventional horror archetypes.

KATHERINE LOVVORN — 18

Popular. Studious. Conscientious.

Katherine is a well-liked high school senior whose outwardly ordinary life conceals an enormous private collection of human hair. At school, she is socially capable, intelligent, and unremarkable in precisely the way the film needs her to be. She does not perform sinister behavior for the audience. Her interest in Harrison gradually brings her public and private worlds together.

HARRISON — 18

Quiet. Lonely. Caring.

Harrison is a reserved classmate of Katherine's living in an unstable home with his volatile mother. Though anxious and somewhat guarded, he becomes open when he feels safe with Katherine during their partner psychology project, as they have gone to school together their whole life and he feels he knows who she is- kind, pretty, and smart. Her attention matters to him because it offers a connection he's never known. His willingness to trust her ultimately places him inside her private world. Harrison never looks weak or pathetic.

MR. LEVERETTE — 35

Composed. Particular. Aging.

A respected psychology teacher whose careful routines introduce the world of Hair. Leverette dresses deliberately, tends to his appearance, and quietly confronts his changing body through ordinary acts of maintenance. The film initially appears as though the story may belong to him (a misdirection inspired by the opening of Thomas Hardy's *The Woodlanders*) before its attention shifts toward his students.

JESSICA & AMANDA — 18

Boisterous. Friendly. Playful.

Katherine's closest friends, Jessica and Amanda belong completely to Katherine's ordinary social world. Their energetic familiarity with Katherine helps establish a genuine friendship before the audience understands how little even people close to Katherine know about her private life. Jessica's naturally red hair later becomes an immediately recognizable physical trace within Katherine's collection.

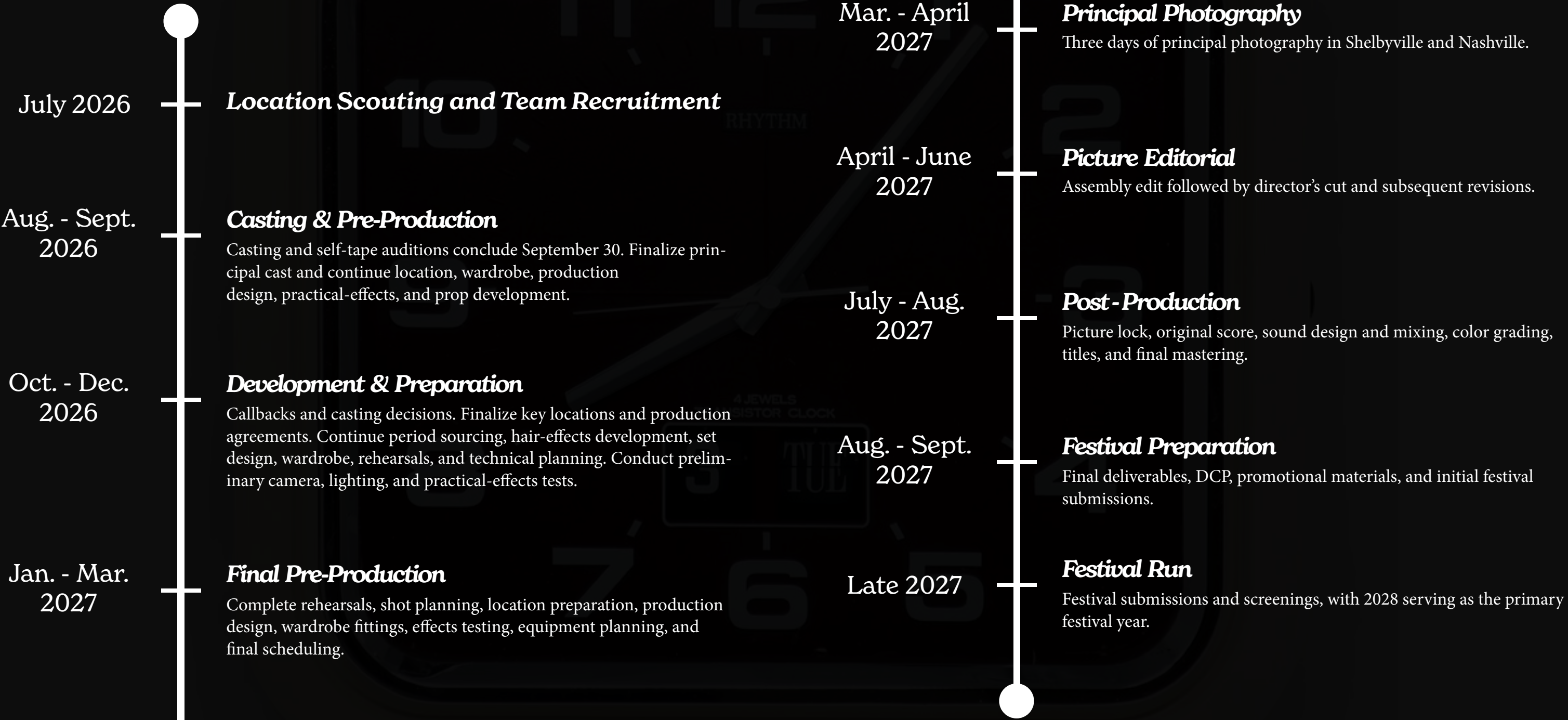
THE WORLD OF HAIR

The setting should feel inhabited rather than dressed for a period film.





PRODUCTION SCHEDULE



THE WHY

We will make *Hair* to the best of our ability regardless of whether we receive additional funding. Our cast and crew have already invested an enormous amount of time, talent, and belief in this project, and we are committed to seeing it through. However, \$12,000 in additional funding would fundamentally change the resources available to us and allow us to make *Hair* in the way we believe the film deserves.

The funding would allow us to secure the locations the story requires without sacrificing shooting time because of cost, expand our lighting and production resources, strengthen our practical effects and period production design, and properly compensate more of the people contributing their time and expertise to the film. It would also give us the flexibility to solve creative and logistical problems based on what is best for the film rather than simply what we can afford.

As the writer and director, I have accepted much of the financial responsibility for bringing *Hair* to life, and I am willing to continue to do so. I knew early on that paying our actors would be nonnegotiable. These roles, especially Katherine's, are demanding and require talent worth compensating as fairly as we can. Our crew is largely made up of volunteers who have generously offered their time and expertise because they believe in the project, and additional funding would allow us to at least cover the basic costs they incur while helping us make the film.

What I do not want is for the limitations of my personal finances to come at the expense of our crew or the quality of the work we are asking them to help create. This grant would relieve a significant amount of that pressure. It would allow us to better support the people giving their time to *Hair*, give our collaborators the resources they need to do their best work, and allow me to focus more fully on directing the film rather than continually weighing creative decisions against what I can personally afford.

We are not looking for funding to determine whether *Hair* gets made. We are looking for funding that will help us do it right. We have spent years developing this story and months assembling the people, locations, designs, and resources necessary to make it real. With this support, we would have the freedom to make creative decisions based less on financial limitation and more on the film we have been imagining.

CURRENT ALLOCATIONS

Cast & Crew	\$1,550
Katherine's House / Location Rental	\$1,000+
Picture Vehicle & Transportation	\$400
Hair SFX & Practical Effects	\$300
Wardrobe, Period Styling, Props	\$350
Meals	\$400
Estimated Total	\$4000

THE TEAM

WRITER & DIRECTOR



W. T. Zackary Smith

CAMERA & LIGHTING



Isaiah W. Smith — Cinematographer &
Graphic Designer



Felix David — Lighting Lead

SET, WARDROBE, & PROPS



Lily K. Smith — Poster & Set Design



Isabel Heuer — Wardrobe Lead



Kristen Smith — Stage Makeup & Production
Assistant



Karen Swing — Hair SFX



Claire Cheney — Stage Makeup & Production
Assistant

PRODUCTION



Corey Simpson — Assistant Director



Forrester Payne — Script Supervisor & Creative
Director



Noah Smith — Mechanical & Technical
Production

SOUND & MUSIC



Jacob McKinney Smith — Composer



Brandon Crosslin — Audio Engineer



Zachary Cartwright — Assistant Audio Engineer

We are in the process of casting. Our self-tape audition window was from August 26th - September 30th. At the time of writing, before the submission deadline, we have had over 200 inquiries and over thirty submissions. We have great contenders for all the major roles and will be conducting call backs during the month of October.

Contact:

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